Reading practice booklet: Grade 6 expectations

Grade 6 · Practice booklet

Name: _____

What this booklet is

This is general practice written for Reading at Grade 6 level, following the Common Core State Standards for English Language Arts standards for that grade. It is not made from your child's MAP questions, and it does not replace the classroom. Use it as a guide to what a child is expected to know and do at this level.

How to use it

- Do one section at a time, about 10 minutes, 3 days a week. Stop while it is still enjoyable.
- Read each question all the way through, twice, before answering. Underline the key words and say what is being asked.
- Take your time. A careful, correct answer is worth more than a fast one.
- Use scrap paper and show the working. Then check the answer before moving on.
- Ask your child to explain how they got an answer, even when it is right.
- If a section feels too hard, do the section before it again, or ask the teacher. That is part of learning, not a problem.

Section 1: Word meanings and how writers use words

Standards practised: RL.6.4, L.6.4a, L.6.4b, L.6.5a, L.6.5c

A worked example

Read: "Do not touch the glass vase. It is delicate, and the slightest knock could shatter it." What does delicate mean?

1. Look for clues near the word. The next part says the slightest knock could shatter it.
2. Something that can be broken by a small knock is easy to break.
3. So delicate means easily broken or damaged.

Easily broken or damaged.

Dawn at the Old Harbour

Maryam and her older cousin Noura stepped onto the wooden jetty at dawn, and the creek greeted them with a golden glow. The water was a sheet of glass, and the old dhows rested against the quay like tired camels at the end of a long journey. Her grandfather Hamdan, a boat repairer, was already at work. The sound of his hammer drifted across the harbour, steady as a heartbeat.

"Hand me that plank," he said. "Be careful. It is fragile, and one crack would spoil a whole morning's work."

Maryam lifted it as gently as a bird's egg. Grandfather Hamdan nodded. "Good. Some people call these boats dusty relics. I call them veterans. Each one has faced wind, salt and storms, and still it floats."

"What did they carry?" Maryam asked.

"Everything," he said. "For hundreds of years, dhows transported dates, pearls, spices and cloth across the sea. Think of the word itself. The prefix trans- means across, and the root port means to carry. So to transport something is to carry it across."

Maryam repeated the word quietly, turning it over like a shell in her palm. Then she noticed a tangle of rope on the deck. She frowned, because it looked hopeless. Her grandfather saw her face. "Do not be discouraged," he said. "Every

knot has an end, and every end can be found. Be patient, and the rope will give way."

She sat down and worked at it for a long while. At first her fingers felt clumsy, and the knot seemed to grow tighter. But she kept going, and at last one loop slid free, then another. When the rope lay straight, she held it up like a trophy.

"You are tenacious," said Grandfather Hamdan. "That means you do not give up easily."

By midday the harbour was bustling, and the heat pressed down like a heavy blanket. Maryam's arms ached, yet she felt light inside. The old boat in front of her no longer looked like a relic. It looked ready for the sea, and she had helped to make it so. As the sun sank toward the water, the creek turned the colour of honey, and she knew she would return.

Questions

1. Grandfather Hamdan says the plank is "fragile" and that "one crack would spoil" the work. Using that clue, what does fragile mean?

   A. Heavy and thick

   B. Easily broken

   C. Smooth and shiny

   D. Old and dusty

2. "The old dhows rested against the quay like tired camels." What does this simile suggest about the dhows?

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3. The hammer sound is "steady as a heartbeat". What does this tell you about how Grandfather Hamdan worked?

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4. "The water was a sheet of glass." Is this a simile or a metaphor, and what does it mean?

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5. Grandfather Hamdan says some people call the boats "dusty relics" but he calls them "veterans". Why does "veterans" feel more respectful?

   A. It means the boats are brand new

   B. It suggests experienced boats that have faced storms and still float

   C. It means the boats are very large

   D. It suggests the boats are dirty and forgotten

6. Grandfather Hamdan explains that trans- means across and port means to carry. What does "transport" mean?

   A. To repair something

   B. To carry something across

   C. To hold something still

   D. To count something carefully

7. Grandfather Hamdan says, "Do not be discouraged." Using the sentences around it, what does discouraged most likely mean?

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8. The rope "looked hopeless". The suffix -less means "without". What does hopeless mean here?

   A. Full of hope

   B. Without hope of being untangled

   C. Very long

   D. Ready to use

9. Maryam turned the word over "like a shell in her palm". What does this simile show about how she treated the word?

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10. Grandfather Hamdan calls Maryam "tenacious". Which of her actions shows this?

    A. She lifted the plank gently

    B. She asked what the dhows carried

    C. She kept working at the knot even when it seemed tighter

    D. She sat down on the deck

11. At the end, the old boat "no longer looked like a relic" to Maryam. Explain what changed in the way she saw it.

Section 2: Reading nonfiction

Standards practised: RI.6.1, RI.6.2, RI.6.4, RI.6.5, RI.6.6, RI.6.8

A worked example

Read: "Camels store fat in their humps. This fat gives them energy on long journeys. A camel can also drink a great deal of water at once." What is the central idea?

1. Ask: what is the whole paragraph mostly about? Camels and how their bodies help them travel far.
2. Each sentence gives a detail that supports that idea.
3. Put the main point in one sentence.

Camels' bodies are well suited to long journeys.

Fresh Water from the Sea

The UAE is a land of sand, sun and very little rain. Rivers do not flow here, and the underground water that people once reached by digging wells is limited. So where does the water in your kitchen tap come from? For many homes, the answer is the sea.

The process is called desalination, which means taking the salt out of water. Seawater is too salty to drink. In a modern plant, the water is first filtered to remove sand and seaweed. Then a pump pushes it at high pressure against a thin sheet called a membrane. The membrane has holes so tiny that water passes through but salt does not. This method is called reverse osmosis. What comes out is clean, fresh water, which is tested and then sent to homes through pipes.

An older method uses heat. The seawater is boiled, and the steam is collected and cooled back into water. The salt is left in the tank. Heating uses a great deal of energy, which is why many newer plants prefer membranes, which need less.

Desalination has brought important benefits. Cities such as Abu Dhabi and Dubai could grow quickly because they had a dependable supply of water, even in a long, dry summer. However, it also brings challenges. Pumping and heating take electricity, and making electricity can add pollution to the air. The salt that is

removed leaves the plant as a very salty liquid called brine. If it is poured back into the sea carelessly, it can harm sea plants and animals near the shore.

Engineers are working on answers. Some plants now run on energy from solar panels. Others release the brine through many small pipes so that it mixes quickly with the sea.

Still, the best answer may begin at home. Every litre saved is a litre that does not need to be made, pumped and carried. Turning off the tap while brushing teeth, fixing a dripping pipe and watering plants in the cool evening all help. Desalination is a clever solution, but it is not a magic one. Using water wisely is a habit that every family can share.

Questions

1. According to the first paragraph, why does the UAE need water from the sea?
   A. Rivers flow fast and carry salt
   B. Wells are too deep to dig
   C. There is little rain, no rivers and limited underground water
   D. The sea is closer than the desert

2. What is the first step in a modern desalination plant?
   A. Boiling the seawater
   B. Pushing water against a membrane
   C. Testing the water
   D. Filtering out sand and seaweed

3. In reverse osmosis, what lets water pass through but keeps the salt out?

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4. How is the older heat method different from the membrane method?
   A. It boils seawater and uses more energy
   B. It uses a membrane with tiny holes
   C. It needs no electricity at all
   D. It leaves the salt in the sea

5. Read: "they had a dependable supply of water, even in a long, dry summer." Using the context, what does dependable mean?

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6. What harm can brine cause, and when?

   A. It can make tap water too salty at home

   B. It can harm sea plants and animals near the shore if poured back carelessly

   C. It can stop the membrane from working

   D. It can dry up the wells

7. Name two ways engineers are trying to solve the problems of desalination.

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8. How does the fourth paragraph fit into the whole passage?

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9. The author writes, "Desalination is a clever solution, but it is not a magic one." What does this mean?

   A. It does not work at all

   B. It helps a great deal but does not solve every problem

   C. It is only used for magic shows

   D. It is cheaper than any other idea

10. The author claims that "the best answer may begin at home." Which reason supports this?

    A. Plants grow best in the evening

    B. Pipes are always dripping

    C. Every litre saved does not need to be made, pumped and carried

    D. Homes are close to the sea

11. What do you think is the author's main purpose in writing this passage? Give evidence.

Section 3: Stories, poems and plays

Standards practised: RL.6.1, RL.6.2, RL.6.3, RL.6.4, RL.6.5, RL.6.6

A worked example

Read: "Omar shook his head at first. But after he tried the climbing wall twice, he laughed and asked for a third turn." How did Omar change?

1. Look at how Omar acts at the start: he shook his head, so he was unwilling.
2. Look at how he acts at the end: he laughed and asked for a third turn.
3. Compare the two: he went from unwilling to eager.

He changed from unwilling to eager.

Hind and the Oryx Talk

On Thursday morning, Mrs. Salma told the class that every student would give a two-minute talk about an animal of the UAE. Hind's stomach twisted like a wrung cloth. She loved animals, and she had read three books about the Arabian oryx, but standing at the front of the room with twenty pairs of eyes on her felt like standing at the edge of a cliff.

Every evening she practised in her bedroom, whispering to the mirror. Her older brother Khalid heard her through the wall. "You sound like a tiny bird in there," he teased, and then he added kindly, "Say it louder. Pretend the wall is the class."

On Monday morning, her turn came. Hind's legs felt heavy as she walked to the front. She opened her notes, and the words on the page blurred. For a long moment she could not make a sound. Someone at the back coughed. Hind wanted to run out of the door.

Then she looked at the picture she had brought: an oryx standing alone on a pale dune, its white coat shining, its long horns pointing straight at the sky. She remembered what she had learned. Oryx had once vanished from the wild, yet careful people had brought them back, one small herd at a time. They had not given up, and neither would she.

"The Arabian oryx," she began, and her voice came out thin as thread. She swallowed and started again. "The Arabian oryx can go a long time without drinking, because it gets moisture from the plants it eats." This time the words

were steadier. She spoke about its pale coat, which reflects the sunlight, and about the herds that now roam protected land. When she finished, the class clapped. Her cheeks were warm, but she was smiling.

Afterwards, Mrs. Salma said, "That was brave."

Hind shook her head. "I was nervous the whole time."

"Exactly," said Mrs. Salma. "Bravery is being nervous and speaking anyway."

That evening, Hind knocked on Khalid's door. "Next time, I will practise out loud," she said. "Thank you for the tip."

Khalid grinned. "Next time?"

"Yes," said Hind, surprising herself. "I think I might even enjoy it."

Questions

1. What task did Mrs. Salma give the class?
   A. A two-minute talk about an animal of the UAE
   B. A poster about the desert
   C. A story about a brother
   D. A reading test about oryx books

2. "Hind's stomach twisted like a wrung cloth." What does this simile show about how she felt?

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3. Who tells this story, and how do you know?
   A. Hind, because it says "I"
   B. Khalid, because he gives advice
   C. Mrs. Salma, because she speaks last
   D. An outside narrator, because it uses "Hind", "she" and "her"

4. What advice did Khalid give Hind, and what attitude did he show?

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5. Why could Hind not speak at first when she reached the front?

   A. She had forgotten her notes

   B. The class was talking loudly

   C. She did not know about oryx

   D. She was so nervous that the words blurred and no sound came out

6. What did Hind do and remember that helped her to begin?

   A. She looked at her picture and remembered people had not given up on the oryx

   B. She asked Khalid to speak for her

   C. She read her notes again silently

   D. She remembered the class clapping

7. "Her voice came out thin as thread." What does this tell you about her voice at that moment?

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8. Why does the author include the story of the oryx being brought back from the wild?

   A. To teach the class where oryx live

   B. To show that oryx are fast runners

   C. It matches Hind's situation: she keeps going when something is hard

   D. To explain why Mrs. Salma set the talk

9. Which sentence best explains Mrs. Salma's idea of bravery?

   A. Brave people never feel nervous

   B. Bravery is being nervous and speaking anyway

   C. Brave people speak loudly

   D. Bravery means practising alone

10. How is Hind different at the end of the story from the beginning?

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11. State a theme of this story and give one detail that supports it.

Answer guide for parents

Section 1: Word meanings and how writers use words

1. B. Easily broken. The clue is in the quote: one crack would spoil the work, so fragile means easily broken. If your child chose A (heavy and thick), they guessed from how a plank looks, not from the clue.
2. A good answer says the dhows were still and tired after long journeys, like worn out camels. Ask: what do tired camels do, and how is a boat resting at the quay like that?
3. A good answer says he worked in a regular, even rhythm, calmly and without stopping suddenly, like a heartbeat. Ask: what is a heartbeat like, and what does that say about his hammering?
4. A good answer says metaphor, because it says the water WAS glass with no "like" or "as", and means the water was very smooth and still. Ask: is there a word like "like" or "as" in that sentence?
5. B. It suggests experienced boats that have faced storms and still float. Veterans are people who have faced hard times and are still going, and the text says each boat faced wind, salt and storms and still floats. If your child chose D (dirty and forgotten), they chose the meaning of dusty relics, which is the less respectful word.
6. B. To carry something across. Trans- means across and port means carry, so transport is to carry across, as Grandfather Hamdan explains. If your child chose A (to repair something), they chose a word from the boat setting instead of using the word parts.
7. A good answer says discouraged means feeling like giving up or losing hope, and uses his next words: be patient. Ask: what does he want her to do instead, and what does that tell you?
8. B. Without hope of being untangled. The suffix -less means without, so hopeless means without hope of being untangled, because the rope looked as if it would never come loose. If your child chose A (full of hope), they chose the opposite, so remind them that -less takes something away.
9. A good answer says she thought about the word slowly and carefully, like looking closely at something interesting. Ask: what do you do when you turn a shell over in your hand?
10. C. She kept working at the knot even when it seemed tighter. Tenacious means not giving up, and she kept working at the knot even when it seemed to grow tighter. If your child chose A (she lifted the plank gently), they picked a true detail that shows care, not one that shows she did not give up.
11. A good answer says it first seemed just an old boat, but after helping to repair it she saw it as valuable and ready for the sea. Ask: what did she do that changed her mind?

Section 2: Reading nonfiction

1. C. There is little rain, no rivers and limited underground water. Paragraph one says there is little rain, no rivers and limited underground water, so the sea is the source. If your child chose B (wells are too deep to dig), they chose a detail that sounds sensible, but the text says well water is limited, not too deep.
2. D. Filtering out sand and seaweed. Paragraph two says the water is first filtered to remove sand and seaweed. If your child chose B (pushing water against a membrane), they chose

the next step, not the first.
3. A thin sheet called a membrane, because its holes are so tiny that water passes through but salt does not.
4. A. It boils seawater and uses more energy. Paragraph three says the seawater is boiled and the steam collected, which uses a great deal of energy. If your child chose B (a membrane with tiny holes), they chose the newer method, which is the one it is being compared with.
5. A good answer says dependable means able to be relied on, steady and always there. Ask: if a water supply is dependable even in a long dry summer, can people count on it?
6. B. It can harm sea plants and animals near the shore if poured back carelessly. The passage says careless pouring of the very salty brine can harm sea plants and animals near the shore. If your child chose A (tap water too salty at home), they chose a worry that sounds sensible, but the text never says that.
7. A good answer names two ways from paragraph five: running plants on solar energy, and releasing brine through many small pipes so it mixes quickly. Ask: where in the text did you find each one?
8. A good answer says paragraph four shows both sides: the benefit (cities could grow) and the challenges (energy, pollution and brine). Ask: which word tells you the paragraph turns to problems?
9. B. It helps a great deal but does not solve every problem. The author says it is clever but not magic, so it helps a great deal without solving every problem, and then asks us to use water wisely. If your child chose A (it does not work at all), they read the word "not" and missed the word "but".
10. C. Every litre saved does not need to be made, pumped and carried. The author's reason is that every litre saved is a litre that does not need to be made, pumped and carried. If your child chose A (plants grow best in the evening), they chose a tip from the list, not the reason the author gives.
11. A good answer says the purpose is to explain how desalination works and to persuade readers to save water, using the last paragraph as evidence. Ask: which paragraph tells families what to do?

Section 3: Stories, poems and plays

1. A. A two-minute talk about an animal of the UAE. The first sentence says every student would give a two-minute talk about an animal of the UAE. If your child chose D (a reading test about oryx books), they chose a detail, because Hind read oryx books to prepare, but that was not the task.
2. A good answer says she felt very nervous and uncomfortable, like cloth being twisted tight. Ask: when have you felt that way before something big?
3. D. An outside narrator, because it uses "Hind", "she" and "her". The narrator uses the names Hind and Khalid with "she" and "her", never "I", so it is an outside narrator. If your child chose A (Hind, because it says "I"), they chose first person, but "I" only appears when a character is speaking.
4. A good answer says he told her to say it louder and pretend the wall was the class, and that he teased a little but was kind. Ask: which words show he was kind and not unkind?
5. D. She was so nervous that the words blurred and no sound came out. The text says the words blurred and for a long moment she could not make a sound, so her nerves stopped

her. If your child chose C (she did not know about oryx), they chose a slip, because the story says she had read three books about oryx.

6. A. She looked at her picture and remembered people had not given up on the oryx. She looked at the picture and remembered that careful people brought the oryx back and did not give up. If your child chose D (she remembered the class clapping), they chose something that happened after she began.
7. A good answer says her voice was very quiet and shaky, thin like a thread. Ask: what does a thread look like, and why would a voice sound like that?
8. C. It matches Hind's situation: she keeps going when something is hard. The oryx story matches Hind's: people did not give up, and neither would she. If your child chose A (to teach the class where oryx live), they chose a fact about oryx, not the reason the author put the story in.
9. B. Bravery is being nervous and speaking anyway. Mrs. Salma says it in her own words: bravery is being nervous and speaking anyway. If your child chose A (brave people never feel nervous), they chose the opposite, because Hind was nervous the whole time and was still called brave.
10. A good answer says Hind dreaded speaking at the start, but at the end she is proud and thinks she might enjoy it again. Ask: what did she say to Khalid that shows the change?
11. A good answer states a theme as a lesson, such as courage means acting even when you are nervous, and backs it with one detail from the story. Ask: which moment in the story shows that?